

1 Learning when to share sunlight: a differentiable
2 simulator and learned tracker control for agrivoltaics
3 on the world’s staple croplands

4 Quang-Vinh Dang*

5 *British University Vietnam, Hung Yen, Vietnam*

6 **Abstract**

Agrivoltaic systems grow crops under photovoltaic (PV) modules and could relieve the competition between food and solar power for land. How much electricity they can produce without compromising food production depends on how sunlight is shared between modules and plants. We built a differentiable agrivoltaic simulator that couples solar geometry, single-axis trackers with backtracking, PV output, crop light and microclimate, a soil-water balance and the SIMPLE crop model with a flowering-stage shade penalty. The PV part agrees with PVGIS at 29 sites ($r = 0.97$, mean bias -4.9%). We trained a neural controller (SALS), initialised from a phenology-based rule and fine-tuned by back-propagation through whole seasons, to set the daily light-sharing level of the trackers, maximising electricity under a 90% yield-retention floor. In a deployable evaluation, the array density of every site was chosen from its historical seasons with the same rule for all controllers. Performance was measured on geographically held-out sites and years, for 400 crop–site pairs representing the harvested area of wheat, rice, maize, soybean and potato, in baseline and $+1.5$, $+2$ and $+3^\circ\text{C}$ climates. At equal mean yield retention (about 0.905), light-sharing control allowed arrays about three times as dense as static arrays. Electricity rose from 217 to 510 MWh ha $^{-1}$ yr $^{-1}$, and the land-equivalent ratio (LER) from 1.07 to 1.27. The learned controller exceeded the best hand-written rule (phenology rule, LER 1.24) by 0.03–0.05 in LER (about 10% more electricity), at 84–86% of the held-out sites, consistently over three seeds, three spatial splits, three canopy-cooling assumptions and all climates. Its advantage did not depend on stress-aware inputs, on training in warmed climates or on weather forecasts, and it held for floors between 0.80 and 0.95: the learned

*Corresponding author
Preprint submitted to *Artificial Intelligence in Agriculture*
Email address: vinh.dq4@buv.edu.vn (Quang-Vinh Dang)

policy is a smooth function of crop phenology. The floor was met in 70% of individual seasons and production-weighted retention was below 0.9 for soybean and maize, so per-site enforcement requires region- and crop-specific design. Equipping 5% of the world’s staple cropland at the floor would yield about 14 PWh yr^{-1} , about half of world generation, but it would need about 10 TWp of modules, 5.7 times the installed global PV capacity. The results quantify how far dynamic control extends agrivoltaics and where the remaining benefit of learning lies.

7 *Keywords:* Agrivoltaics, Differentiable simulation, Food–energy nexus,
8 Solar tracking, Crop modelling, Learned control

9 1. Introduction

10 Two of the defining challenges of this century compete for the same re-
11 source: land. The energy transition requires terawatts of new solar pho-
12 tovoltaic (PV) capacity, and ground-mounted solar farms need roughly one
13 to two hectares per megawatt. Food production must rise while crops are
14 exposed to more frequent heat waves and droughts. Warming alone is pro-
15 jected to reduce global yields of maize, wheat, rice and soybean by several
16 per cent per degree (Zhao et al., 2017), and a new generation of climate and
17 crop models shows these impacts emerging earlier than previously expected
18 (Jägermeyr et al., 2021). Croplands are also where solar power potential is
19 greatest (Adeh et al., 2019). They are flat, sunny, accessible and close to
20 rural electricity demand, so converting farmland into solar farms is tempting
21 and controversial at the same time.

22 Agrivoltaic (AV) systems combine crops and PV modules on the same
23 land and aim to resolve this conflict (Dupraz et al., 2011; Dinesh and Pearce,
24 2016; Weselek et al., 2019). By sharing sunlight between modules and plants,
25 a hectare can deliver more food plus energy than the two uses side by side,
26 with land-equivalent ratios (LER) well above one in field trials and mod-
27 elling studies (Dupraz et al., 2011; Amaducci et al., 2018; Valle et al., 2017;
28 Trommsdorff et al., 2021). The partial shade also changes the crop micro-
29 climate. It lowers canopy temperature and evaporative demand, conserves
30 soil moisture and improves water-use efficiency, especially in drylands (Mar-
31 rou et al., 2013b; Hassanpour Adeh et al., 2018; Barron-Gafford et al., 2019;
32 Elamri et al., 2018; Weselek et al., 2021). Agrivoltaics is therefore a candi-
33 date adaptation measure against heat and drought stress, in addition to a

mitigation measure through renewable electricity. The same shade, however, also reduces the light available for photosynthesis. Regulators increasingly require AV systems to retain most of the reference crop yield. The German pre-standard DIN SPEC 91434, for example, requires at least 66% of the reference yield (DIN, 2021), and other schemes and many farmers set stricter floors. How much electricity can be produced without sacrificing food security depends on the crop, the local climate, the year and the growth stage.

Most AV designs fix the geometry of the array, i.e. the ground coverage ratio (GCR, module area per ground area) and the tilt or tracking rule, from generic rules of thumb. Single-axis trackers add a degree of freedom: the modules can be rotated away from the sun to let light through when the crop needs it, as demonstrated for lettuce by Valle et al. (2017), or towards the sun to maximise electricity. Choosing the rotation every day is a sequential decision problem. The value of light depends on the crop’s phenological stage, soil water and upcoming weather, and the effect of a decision appears in the harvest months later. Recent work in this journal has used evolutionary multi-objective optimisation to lay out PV arrays on farmland (Zhang et al., 2026). Machine learning for crop management has mainly used reinforcement learning with black-box simulators (Gautron et al., 2022), which is sample-inefficient and hard to scale to global, multi-decadal assessments.

Two questions follow. First, how much of the electricity that an agri-voltaic system can produce under a food-security floor depends on the array density, and how much on dynamic control of the trackers? Second, can a controller learned from a simulator improve on a well-designed hand-written rule, and under which conditions? Answering them requires a simulator that couples the physics of light, PV, microclimate and crop growth, a fair protocol in which all controllers face the same design constraints, and enough sites and seasons to separate real effects from noise.

This paper makes three contributions. The first is a differentiable agri-voltaic simulator that couples hourly solar geometry, single-axis trackers with backtracking, row-to-row shading and PV electricity, the direct and diffuse light reaching the crop, a microclimate model of canopy temperature and reference evapotranspiration under the modules, and the SIMPLE crop model (Zhao et al., 2019) extended with a flowering-stage shade penalty. All components are differentiable tensor operations, so a neural controller can be trained by back-propagation through entire growing seasons (Karniadakis et al., 2021). The PV part of the simulator is benchmarked against PVGIS. The second is SALS (simulation-trained adaptive light sharing), a controller

that maps the daily crop and soil state, the array density and a noisy weather forecast to a daily light-sharing level, initialised from a phenology-based rule and fine-tuned through the simulator to maximise electricity under a yield-retention floor. The third is a deployable evaluation protocol. The array density of every site is chosen from its historical seasons only, with the same rule for every controller, and performance is measured on held-out sites and years, over three training seeds and three spatial splits.

We apply the protocol to 400 crop–site pairs that represent where maize, wheat, rice, soybean and potato are grown worldwide, sampled in proportion to their harvested area (Yu et al., 2020) with local crop calendars (Jägermeyr et al., 2021), and driven by NASA POWER daily weather for 2001–2019 (Sparks, 2018) under baseline and +1.5, +2 and +3 °C climates. The main findings are as follows.

1. Light sharing is the main lever. At the same mean yield retention of 90%, arrays with light-sharing control carry about three times the module area of static arrays and produce 1.8–2.4 times as much electricity (Section 3.1).
2. A learned controller improves on the best hand-written rule by 0.03–0.05 in land-equivalent ratio (about 10% more electricity at equal retention). The gain is consistent over seeds, spatial splits, canopy-cooling assumptions and climates, and it occurs at 84–86% of the held-out sites.
3. The improvement does not come from reacting to heat or drought, and it needs neither training in warmed climates nor weather forecasts. The learned policy is a smooth function of crop phenology (Section 3.4), and one network serves floors between 0.80 and 0.95 (Section 3.3).
4. At the yield floor, agrivoltaics on 5% of the world’s staple cropland could supply about 14 PWh yr^{−1}, but only with about 10 TWp of modules, several times the installed PV capacity of the world (Section 3.8).

2. Materials and methods

2.1. Global cropland sites, weather and crop calendars

We studied five staple crops that together cover about 670 Mha of harvested area and 580 Mha of physical cropland: wheat, rice, maize, soybean and potato. Harvested areas (rainfed and irrigated) were taken from the SPAM 2010 gridded production maps (Yu et al., 2020) and aggregated to 1° cells. For each crop, 80 cells with at least 5000 ha of the crop were drawn

without replacement with probability proportional to harvested area. An unweighted average over the sample therefore approximates an area-weighted average over global production. The 400 crop-site pairs lie in 381 distinct cells in 50 countries (Fig. 2). Sowing and maturity dates came from the GGCM Phase 3 crop calendar at 0.5° (Jägermeyr et al., 2021). For wheat we used the winter-wheat calendar unless the coldest-month mean temperature was below -8°C , in which case the spring-wheat calendar was used. Daily weather for 2001–2020 was retrieved from NASA POWER (Sparks, 2018): global and diffuse shortwave irradiance, maximum, minimum and dew-point temperature, precipitation and wind speed at 2 m. Each site contributes 19 seasons (sowing years 2001–2019), each simulated as the 365 days after sowing, which gives 7600 site-seasons.

Climate change was represented by the global warming levels $+1.5$, $+2$ and $+3^\circ\text{C}$ relative to 2001–2020. Daily maximum, minimum and dew-point temperatures were shifted uniformly, which keeps relative humidity approximately constant and raises the vapour-pressure deficit. The atmospheric CO_2 concentration was set to 390, 450, 500 and 600 ppm for the baseline and the three warming levels. Precipitation and irradiance were left unchanged. This delta approach isolates the thermal signal of warming; its limitations are discussed in Section 4.4.

2.2. A differentiable agrivoltaic simulator

The simulator advances all site-seasons in parallel with a daily time step for the crop and an hourly time step for radiation and PV (Fig. 1). All equations are implemented as PyTorch tensor operations (Paszke et al., 2019), so that yields and electricity are differentiable with respect to the design and control variables.

Hourly irradiance. Daily global and diffuse irradiance were disaggregated into hourly values with the Collares-Pereira and Rabl (1979) and Liu and Jordan (1960) ratios and renormalised to the daily totals. Beam irradiance on the horizontal is the difference between the two. Solar position follows the standard declination and hour-angle equations.

Array geometry and PV electricity. We consider elevated horizontal single-axis trackers with north–south axes. The axis height is 1.25 module widths, e.g. 2.75 m for the common 2.2-m single-module-high (1P) tracker. The rotation ϕ is limited to $\pm 60^\circ$. The ground coverage ratio g is the module width

divided by the row pitch and is restricted to $g \leq 0.5$. For 2.2-m modules this keeps a pitch of at least 4.4 m, and a free strip of at least 2.2 m between the rows when the modules are horizontal, which is the stow position during field operations. Let ψ be the solar zenith angle projected onto the east–west vertical plane. The energy-optimal rotation with backtracking (Lorenzo et al., 2011) is $\phi_{\text{bt}} = \psi - \text{sgn}(\psi) \arccos(\cos \psi / g)$ when $\cos \psi < g$, and $\phi_{\text{bt}} = \psi$ otherwise. The *light-sharing* rotation ϕ_{sh} is the feasible angle closest to edge-on to the sun, which minimises the shadow on the crop. Given a light-sharing level $u \in [0, 1]$ chosen once per day, the rotation in every hour is

$$\phi = (1 - u) \phi_{\text{bt}} + u \phi_{\text{sh}}. \quad (1)$$

Plane-of-array irradiance combines three terms: beam irradiance on the module, reduced by the fraction of the module shaded by the neighbouring row, $\max\{0, 1 - \cos \psi / (g |\cos(\phi - \psi)|)\}$; isotropic sky diffuse; and ground-reflected light (albedo 0.2). The cell temperature follows the NOCT model (45 °C), with an hourly air temperature interpolated sinusoidally between the daily extremes. Electricity per unit land is plane-of-array irradiance $\times \eta \times g$, with $\eta = 0.21 [1 - 0.0035(T_{\text{cell}} - 25)] (1 - 0.14)$ for module efficiency, temperature losses and system losses. The installed capacity is 2.1 g MWp ha^{−1}. A conventional ground-mounted PV plant ($g = 0.4$, backtracking, no crop) is the energy reference E_{PV} .

Validation of the PV model. We compared the simulated specific yield of an isolated tracker row ($g = 0.05$, negligible row-to-row shading) with PVGIS 5.2 (European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2022), for a horizontal north–south single-axis tracker with 14% losses, at 30 randomly chosen sites (29 returned data). Across sites, the simulated and PVGIS specific yields were correlated with $r = 0.971$. The simulator was on average 4.9% lower (mean absolute deviation 5.5%). This is consistent with its $\pm 60^\circ$ rotation limit and with the different irradiance databases (NASA POWER vs. SARA2, ERA5 and NSRDB). Electricity estimates are therefore, if anything, conservative.

Light and microclimate at the crop. Averaged over the row pitch, the fraction of ground reached by beam light is $1 - \min\{1, g |\cos(\phi - \psi)| / \cos \psi\}$. The fraction of sky diffuse reaching the ground is a two-dimensional isotropic sky-view factor. We pre-computed it for 25 values of g and 13 rotation angles by ray casting over 31 neighbouring rows, and interpolate it bilinearly (differentiably). The daily ratio s of the irradiance at the crop to that of the

open field defines the crop’s shading. The canopy maximum temperature is lowered by $\kappa(1 - s)$.

κ is uncertain. Field studies under PV modules report small reductions of daytime crop or canopy temperature and little change in air temperature (Marrou et al., 2013b; Barron-Gafford et al., 2019), and heat-stress thresholds calibrated on air temperature do not transfer directly to canopy temperature (Siebert et al., 2014; Webber et al., 2018). We therefore use a moderate $\kappa = 1^\circ\text{C}$ as the main case and report $\kappa = 0$ (no cooling) and $\kappa = 2^\circ\text{C}$ for all methods (Section 3.2). Nocturnal warming under the modules is not represented. The reference evapotranspiration under the modules, ET_0 , is re-computed with the FAO-56 Penman–Monteith equation (Allen et al., 1998) from the reduced radiation and canopy temperature. Soil water conservation under the modules (Hassanpour Adeh et al., 2018; Elamri et al., 2018) therefore emerges from the model, but rain redistribution by the modules (Marrou et al., 2013a) is ignored.

Crop growth. Crop growth follows the SIMPLE model (Zhao et al., 2019) with the species parameters of its Table 1a (Table 1). Daily biomass growth is

$$\Delta B = R_{\text{crop}} \cdot \text{RUE} \cdot f_{\text{Solar}} \cdot f_{\text{CO}_2} \cdot f_{\text{Temp}} \cdot \min\{f_{\text{Heat}}, f_{\text{Water}}\}, \quad (2)$$

where $R_{\text{crop}} = sR$ is the radiation received by the crop. The terms are as follows.

- f_{Solar} is the canopy’s radiation interception. In SIMPLE it depends only on thermal time, with senescence accelerated by heat and drought stress. Shade therefore reduces the daily biomass increment but not leaf-area development.
- f_{Heat} decreases linearly between the heat threshold T_{heat} and the extreme temperature T_{ext} of the canopy maximum temperature.
- $f_{\text{Water}} = 1 - S_{\text{water}} \text{ ARID}$, where the agricultural reference index for drought (Woli et al., 2012) is computed from a daily soil-water balance with curve-number runoff, drainage and root water uptake. Irrigated fields have $f_{\text{Water}} = 1$.

SIMPLE has a fixed harvest index and therefore ignores the high sensitivity of grain number to shading around flowering (Fischer, 1985; Andrade et al., 1999). It also ignores the differences in shade tolerance between crop types. In the meta-analysis of Laub et al. (2022), maize and

210 grain legumes lost yield strongly even at low shade levels, whereas C3 ce-
 211 reals and tuber crops initially lost less than proportionally; shading trials
 212 also show marked effects of shade on maize development (Ramos-Fuentes
 213 et al., 2023). We added a stage-dependent penalty. During a critical window
 214 ($0.45 \leq TT/T_{\text{sum}} \leq 0.65$), the harvest index is multiplied by $1 - h \bar{d}$, where $\bar{d}$
 215 is the mean relative radiation deficit $1 - s$ in that window. The sensitivity h
 216 is highest for maize (0.6) and soybean (0.5), the crop types that Laub et al.
 217 (2022) found most shade-sensitive, lower for the C3 cereals (wheat 0.4; rice
 218 0.5, for which no specific curve was available) and lowest for potato (0.2).
 219 These values are assumptions that reproduce this ranking; they are not cal-
 220 ibrated estimates. Section 3.6 shows the resulting shade-response curves.
 221 Because RUE is linear, SIMPLE does not credit the higher light-use effi-
 222 ciency of shaded canopies under more diffuse light. The penalty, conversely,
 223 makes shading around flowering more damaging than proportional. The net
 224 effect is closer to the field evidence than either assumption alone.

225 The thermal-time requirement to maturity was calibrated for every site as
 226 the mean thermal time between the GGCMI sowing and maturity dates under
 227 the 2001–2020 climate, and the canopy parameters were scaled accordingly.
 228 The cultivar is thus adapted to the present climate, and warming shortens the
 229 season. Growth stops smoothly once the thermal-time requirement is met.
 230 Yield is biomass multiplied by the (shade-adjusted) harvest index. Each site
 231 is represented by a rainfed and an irrigated sub-field in proportion to its
 232 SPAM irrigated fraction. Each sub-field carries its own array, so both yield
 233 and electricity are area-weighted over the two sub-fields.

234 2.3. SALS: simulation-trained adaptive light sharing

235 SALS learns a *control network* $u_t = \pi_\omega(\mathbf{x}_t; g)$ (Algorithm 1). It is a
 236 multilayer perceptron with two hidden layers of 64 units and a bounded-logit
 237 output, $u = \sigma(5 \tanh(z/5)) \in [0.007, 0.993]$, which keeps gradients non-zero
 238 at the extremes. It chooses the daily light-sharing level of Eq. (1). Its inputs
 239 are the information available on day t :

- 240 • the crop and soil state: relative thermal time TT/T_{sum} , radiation in-
 241 terception f_{Solar} , relative soil water and the previous day’s ARID;
- 242 • a *forecast* of the day’s maximum temperature (relative to T_{heat} and
 243 T_{opt}), irradiance and ET_0 ;

- static information: the irrigation status of the sub-field, the array’s GCR g , latitude, day of season and the crop.

Forecasts are perturbed with random errors, independently every day: Gaussian with a standard deviation of 2 °C for maximum temperature, and multiplicative with standard deviations of 20% for irradiance and 15% for ET_0 . The physics always uses the true weather. The same forecast errors are applied to the rule-based controllers. The controller is conditioned on g . During training, each season is simulated with a GCR close to the density that is sustainable at its training site. This is the largest value on a coarse grid (0.05, 0.10, ..., 0.50) at which seasonal sharing keeps the mean retention of the site’s training seasons at or above ρ , plus a uniform perturbation in $[-0.05, +0.10]$ truncated to $[0.05, 0.50]$. The network therefore learns to control the densities that design selection will later pick. Outside the cropping season the trackers backtrack for maximum electricity.

For site-season i with open-field yield Y_i^{open} , let $r_i = Y_i/Y_i^{\text{open}}$ be the yield retention and $e_i = E_i/E_{\text{PV},i}$ the electricity relative to a conventional PV plant. Training minimises the penalised objective

$$\mathcal{L}(\omega) = \mathbb{E}_{i \sim \mathcal{B}} \left[-e_i + \mu_1 \max\{0, \rho - r_i\} + \mu_2 \max\{0, \rho - r_i\}^2 \right], \quad \rho = 0.9, \mu_1 = 5, \mu_2 = 30, \quad (3)$$

which combines an exact (hinge) and a quadratic penalty for the food-security floor ρ . Because r_i and e_i are outputs of the differentiable simulator, the exact gradient of Eq. (3) is obtained by back-propagation through the 365 daily steps of every season (back-propagation through time). This is the key difference from reinforcement learning with black-box simulators (Gautron et al., 2022), which estimates gradients from sampled returns.

Each minibatch contains 512 site-seasons, each simulated as a rainfed and an irrigated sub-field, drawn from one of the four climates in turn. Seasons with a failed open-field crop ($Y^{\text{open}} < 0.2 \text{ t ha}^{-1}$) are excluded from training and evaluation. The network is fine-tuned through the simulator with Adam (Kingma and Ba, 2015) (learning rate 10^{-3} , cosine decay, gradient-norm clipping at 1) for 300 steps. Growth-stage logistic functions are evaluated in a numerically stable form, so that gradients remain finite even under extreme heat.

Initialisation. Trained from random weights, the controller converged to sharing light throughout the cropping window ($u > 0.99$ on all days), i.e. to the seasonal-sharing rule, because the gradient of electricity with respect to u

Algorithm 1 SALS training

Require: training site-seasons in four climates; floor ρ ; penalties μ_1, μ_2

- 1: initialise π_ω by behaviour cloning of the phenology rule
- 2: **for** step = $1, \dots, N$ **do**
- 3: sample a climate and a minibatch $\mathcal{B}$ of site-seasons (rainfed and irrigated sub-fields)
- 4: set g_i to the site’s sustainable density plus a perturbation; initialise crop and soil states
- 5: **for** day $t = 1, \dots, 365$ **do**
- 6: $u_{it} \leftarrow \pi_\omega(\mathbf{x}_{it}; g_i)$ from state and noisy forecast if the crop is in the field, else 0
- 7: hourly rotation (Eq. 1), PV electricity, crop light, canopy temperature, ET_0
- 8: advance the soil-water balance and the SIMPLE crop state (Eq. 2)
- 9: $r_i \leftarrow Y_i/Y_i^{\text{open}}, e_i \leftarrow E_i/E_{PV,i}$ (area-weighted); loss $\mathcal{L}$ (Eq. 3)
- 10: back-propagate through the season; Adam update of ω

278 is small and of the same sign for most days of a season. We therefore initialise
279 the network by behaviour cloning of the phenology rule of Section 2.4: binary
280 cross-entropy against the rule’s output (soft targets 0.95 and 0.05) on about
281 1.7 million day-states visited by the rule in the training seasons, with 1500
282 Adam steps at a learning rate of 3×10^{-3} . Fine-tuning then moves the
283 policy away from this initialisation wherever doing so improves the objective.
284 Consequently, the gain of SALS over the phenology rule measures what fine-
285 tuning through the simulator adds to that rule, not what can be learned
286 without it.

287 2.4. Deployable design selection and baselines

288 A real array has one fixed density, which must be chosen before it is built.
289 Every method, SALS included, therefore uses the same *history-based design*
290 *rule*. For a site, the GCR is the largest value on the grid $\{0.05, 0.075, \dots, 0.50\}$
291 for which the method’s mean yield retention over the site’s 2001–2014 sea-
292 sons is at least $\rho = 0.9$. If no value qualifies, no array is built and the site
293 remains open field. A stricter *chance-constrained* variant requires $r \geq 0.9$ in
294 at least 80% of the historical seasons. The historical seasons of the test sites
295 are never used for training, and the weather of the evaluation years is never
296 used for design. We compare four controllers:

- 297 • *AV static*: backtracking trackers without light sharing ($u = 0$);
- 298 • *Seasonal sharing*: the light-sharing rotation ($u = 1$) throughout the
299 cropping season;
- 300 • *Stress rule*: an expert rule that shares light ($u = 1$) during the main
301 growth phase ($0.1 < TT/T_{\text{sum}} < 0.9$) except on days with a heat-stress
302 forecast ($T_{\text{max}} \geq T_{\text{heat}}$) or drought ($\text{ARID} > 0.5$), when the modules
303 track the sun and shade the crop;
- 304 • *SALS*: the learned controller.

305 The open field and a conventional PV plant without crops ($\text{LER} = 1$ each)
306 are the references. Because the design rule is identical for all controllers, dif-
307 ferences between methods reflect the quality of control and the array density
308 that each controller can sustain under the food-security floor. We also com-
309 pare the controllers at identical GCR over the whole grid (matched-density
310 frontiers).

311 2.5. Evaluation protocol, statistics and upscaling

312 Sites were split spatially: $10^\circ \times 10^\circ$ blocks were randomly assigned to train-
313 ing (70%) or test (30%), so that no test site has a training site in the same
314 block. Training uses the 2001–2014 seasons of the training sites. Design
315 selection uses the 2001–2014 seasons of the test sites. Evaluation uses the
316 2015–2019 seasons of the test sites. The same site-seasons are analysed in all
317 four climates.

318 We report the following metrics:

- 319 • the mean electricity ($\text{MWh ha}^{-1} \text{yr}^{-1}$) and the relative electricity e ;
- 320 • the mean yield retention r and the production-weighted retention $\sum Y / \sum Y^{\text{open}}$;
- 321 • season-level compliance (share of seasons with $r \geq \rho$) and site-level
322 compliance (share of sites whose mean test-season retention is $\geq \rho$);
- 323 • the lower tail (10th percentile of r , share of seasons with $r < 0.8$);
- 324 • the land-equivalent ratio $\text{LER} = r + e$ (Dupraz et al., 2011).

Table 1: SIMPLE crop parameters (Zhao et al., 2019, Table 1a) and the harvest-index shade sensitivity h added in this study. T_{sum} , I_{50A} and I_{50B} are rescaled per site to the local crop calendar (Section 2.2). Units: temperatures in $^{\circ}\text{C}$, thermal times in $^{\circ}\text{C d}$, RUE in gMJ^{-1} ; S_{CO_2} is the relative RUE increase per 100 ppm above 350 ppm.

Crop (cultivar)	h	T_{sum}	HI	I_{50A}	I_{50B}	T_{base}	T_{opt}	RUE	$I_{50 \text{ max } H}$	$I_{50 \text{ max } W}$	T_{heat}	T_{ext}	S_{CO_2}	S_{water}
Wheat (Batten)	0.4	2150	0.34	280	50	0	15	1.24	100	25	34	45	0.08	0.4
Rice (IR72)	0.5	2300	0.47	850	200	9	26	1.24	100	10	34	50	0.08	1.0
Maize (McCurdy 84aa)	0.6	2050	0.50	500	50	8	28	2.10	100	12	34	50	0.01	1.2
Soybean (Williams 82)	0.5	2350	0.40	600	200	6	27	0.86	120	20	36	50	0.07	0.9
Potato (Sebago)	0.2	2400	0.85	500	350	4	22	1.30	50	30	34	45	0.10	0.4

Statistical comparisons use site means as the unit of analysis. We report paired Wilcoxon signed-rank tests and cluster (site) bootstrap 95% confidence intervals of the mean difference. SALS was trained with three random seeds on the main split, and with one seed on each of two further spatial splits.

For the global estimate, every site is evaluated in the split in which it is held out. The mean electricity and yield per hectare of each crop are scaled to the *physical* area of that crop in SPAM 2010, which avoids double counting multiple-cropped land (Waha et al., 2020). We report the installed capacity (TWp), the capacity factor and a supply curve.

3. Results

3.1. Electricity and food on held-out sites and years

Table 2 compares the four controllers on the 92 held-out sites of the main split (seasons sown in 2015–2019), after each site’s density has been chosen from its 2001–2014 seasons with the same rule for all controllers. By construction all methods keep the mean yield retention close to 90% (0.904–0.917), so differences in electricity are differences in the density that each controller can sustain under this floor.

Static arrays are the weakest. Without light sharing, the floor limits the ground coverage to 6% on average, and arrays produce $217 \text{ MWh ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$, 16% of a conventional PV plant per hectare (LER 1.07). Rotating the modules to let light through during the cropping season (seasonal sharing) allows a coverage of 17% and $397 \text{ MWh ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ (LER 1.19). A rule that shares light only while the crop is growing (phenology rule) reaches $465 \text{ MWh ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ (LER 1.24). An expert rule that additionally shades the

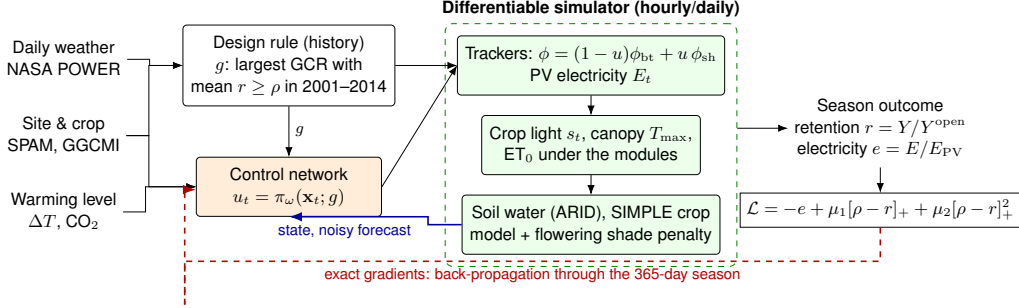


Figure 1: Simulator and controller. The array density g of a site is fixed from its historical seasons. A control network maps the daily crop and soil state, the density g and a noisy forecast to the light-sharing level u_t . The differentiable simulator converts these decisions into PV electricity, light and microclimate at the crop, soil water and crop growth. The season’s electricity and yield retention enter a penalised objective whose exact gradient is back-propagated through the 365-day season.

350 crop on forecast heat or drought days (stress rule) is worse than the phenol-
 351 ogy rule (LER 1.18): its density is limited to 13% because it reduces light at
 352 times when the floor is most binding.

353 **The learned controller is best by a modest, consistent margin.**
 354 SALS sustains a density of 17% (similar to the phenology rule), produces
 355 510 MWh ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ and reaches an LER of 1.270 at the same retention. Com-
 356 pared with the phenology rule this is +0.038 in LER (95% CI over sites
 357 0.025–0.053; +10% electricity) and it is higher at 84% of the 92 sites (Ta-
 358 ble A.4). Compared with static arrays it is +0.205 (0.176–0.236), with 2.35
 359 times the electricity at 2.9 times the density. The frontier in Fig. 3 shows
 360 the same picture at matched densities: the learned policy lies on or slightly
 361 above the phenology rule over the whole density range, both lie well above
 362 seasonal sharing and the stress rule, and static arrays are far below.

363 **What the floor does and does not guarantee.** Enforcing the floor
 364 on the historical mean does not guarantee it in every season. In the test
 365 seasons, 70% of SALS seasons have $r \geq 0.9$ (phenology rule 69%, stress rule
 366 76%, static arrays 93%), and 2.7% have $r < 0.8$ (1.3%, 0.9% and 0.9%).
 367 The lower tail of SALS is therefore slightly heavier than that of the rules:
 368 its 10th percentile of r is 0.883, against 0.887, 0.886 and 0.903. Requiring
 369 $r \geq 0.9$ in at least 80% of a site’s historical seasons (chance-constrained
 370 design) raises the season-level compliance to 90–94% for the light-sharing
 371 controllers. It costs about 0.065 in LER for SALS (1.205), which remains the

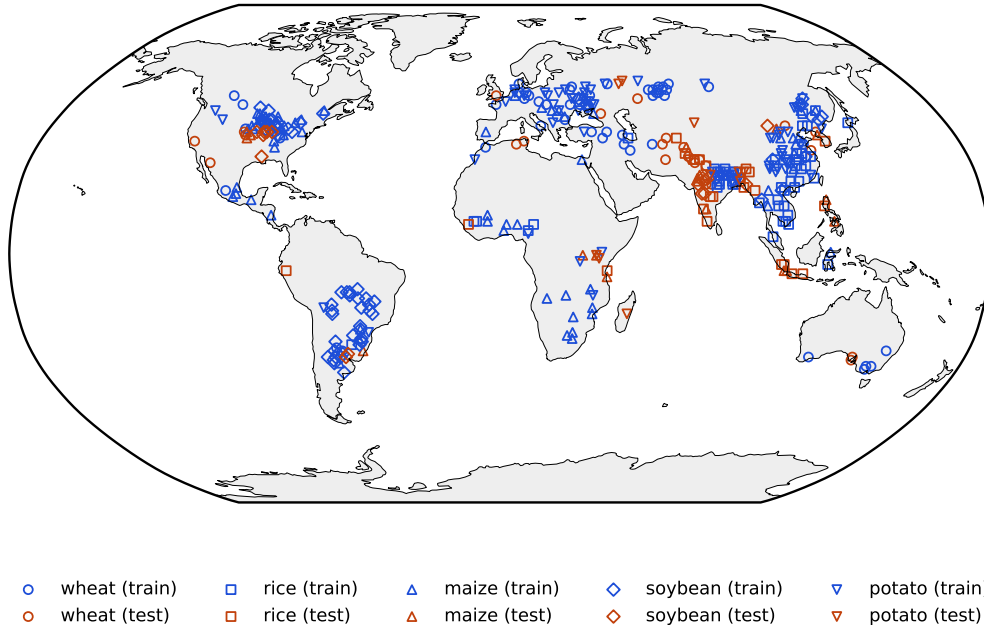


Figure 2: The 400 crop–site pairs, sampled in proportion to the harvested area of each crop (SPAM 2010). Blue: training sites; orange: geographically held-out test sites of the main split.

best controller (phenology rule 1.192; Section 3.2).

3.2. Robustness

Seeds and splits. Three training seeds of SALS give LERs of 1.270, 1.268 and 1.269 under the baseline climate and 1.297, 1.298 and 1.297 at +3 °C. On two further spatial splits, in which different blocks of sites are held out, SALS exceeds the phenology rule by 0.047 and 0.041 in LER under the baseline climate and by 0.052 and 0.039 at +3 °C (main split: 0.034 and 0.032). In every split SALS ranks first, the phenology rule second and static arrays last.

Canopy cooling. The canopy-cooling coefficient κ is the most uncertain microclimate parameter. We repeated the whole protocol, including the historical design step, with $\kappa = 0, 1$ and 2 °C. Electricity changes with κ because cooler canopies tolerate denser arrays (SALS: 475, 510 and 549 MWh ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ under the baseline climate), but the retention is held at 0.905 by the design rule and the ranking is unchanged. SALS exceeds the

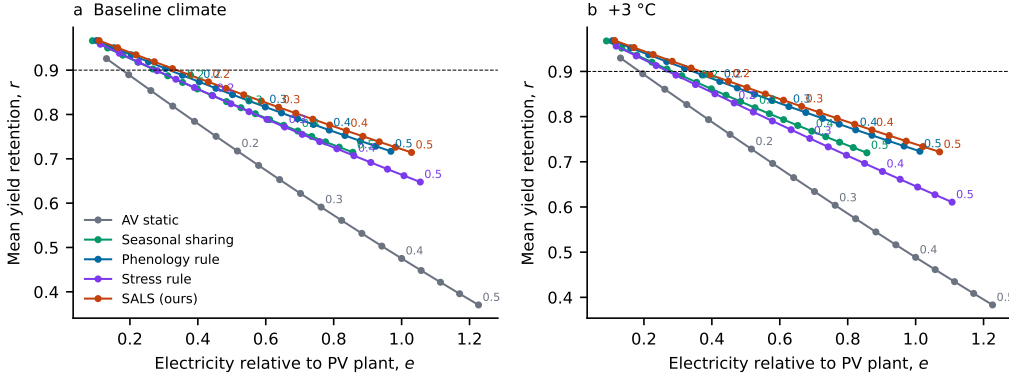


Figure 3: Electricity-retention frontiers at identical array densities (labels: GCR) for the held-out sites. Each point is the mean over test seasons at a fixed GCR; the dashed line is the 90% floor.

phenology rule by 0.029, 0.034 and 0.042 in LER under the baseline climate (0.022, 0.032 and 0.051 at +3 °C).

Which ingredients matter. Two ablations test the design of SALS at the same training budget. Masking the stress inputs (soil water, ARID, and the maximum temperature, irradiance and ET_0 forecasts) leaves the LER unchanged (1.269 vs 1.270 under the baseline climate, 1.297 vs 1.297 at +3 °C). Training only on the baseline climate gives 1.268 and 1.291. The improvement over the rules therefore does not depend on stress-aware inputs or on training in warmed climates.

3.3. Floor conditioning, chance-constrained training and forecast errors

One network for all floors. Regulations and farmers set different floors. The network of the main experiments was trained at $\rho = 0.9$ only. We evaluated it at floors of 0.80, 0.85, 0.90 and 0.95, re-running the historical design step for each floor (Table 3). Its LER exceeds that of the phenology rule by 0.037, 0.036, 0.034 and 0.033 under the baseline climate (0.040, 0.037, 0.032 and 0.033 at +3 °C), so the benefit carries over to other floors without retraining. A network that received the floor as an additional input and was trained over all four floors did not improve on it (differences in LER ≤ 0.001). Because the design step already adapts the density to the floor, conditioning the controller on the floor is not needed.

Chance-constrained training. We also trained a network whose objective penalises a batch share of seasons below the floor that exceeds 20%.

409 It did not improve the tail. With the mean-based design step its LER was
 410 1.263 (baseline) and 1.290 (+3 °C) against 1.270 and 1.297, and with chance-
 411 constrained design it reached season-level compliance of 92.6% against 92.0%
 412 and an LER of 1.198 against 1.205. The season-level guarantee is obtained
 413 by the design step (Section 3.1), not by the training objective.

414 **Forecast errors.** We raised the forecast errors seen by the controllers
 415 to 0, 1, 2 and 3 times the errors used in training. The LER of SALS and
 416 of the phenology rule was identical at all four error levels to three decimals
 417 (densities 0.2 and 0.3: SALS 1.307 and 1.457, phenology rule 1.278 and
 418 1.416). Neither controller uses the weather forecast: both rely on the crop’s
 419 thermal time, which is observable from on-farm temperature records. The
 420 stress rule, which depends on the forecast of maximum temperature, degrades
 421 with forecast error: at density 0.3 its retention falls from 0.778 to 0.751 and
 422 its LER from 1.432 to 1.418 as the errors triple.

423 3.4. *What the learned policy does*

424 Averaged over the rainfed test seasons of the main split at a density of 0.3,
 425 the light-sharing level of SALS is a smooth function of relative thermal time.
 426 It is close to zero in the first 10% of the thermal time required for maturity,
 427 rises through 0.55 at 10–20%, stays at 0.94–0.99 between 30% and 70%, and
 428 falls through 0.58 at 80–90% to about zero at maturity. The plateau covers
 429 the window in which our crop model penalises shading through the harvest
 430 index. The ramps at both ends let the modules produce electricity when
 431 additional light is worth least to the crop. Fig. 4 shows two example seasons.
 432 The phenology rule, which is also the initialisation of the network, shares
 433 light during the whole growing period. Fine-tuning through the simulator
 434 found that sharing can be reduced at the edges of the season: SALS gains its
 435 advantage by yielding light when it matters and collecting electricity when
 436 it matters less.

437 The policy also shares less light on days with a forecast heat stress: the
 438 mean level is 0.35 on such days against 0.60 (baseline) and 0.51 (+3 °C)
 439 on other days, and 58–63% of sites show a lower level on heat days. This
 440 cannot be read as a stress response, however. Heat days occur late in the
 441 season, when the phenological ramp is already falling, and a policy without
 442 any stress input shows a similar contrast (0.37 vs 0.57 in a separate check).
 443 The ablation above confirms that stress information does not improve the
 444 result.

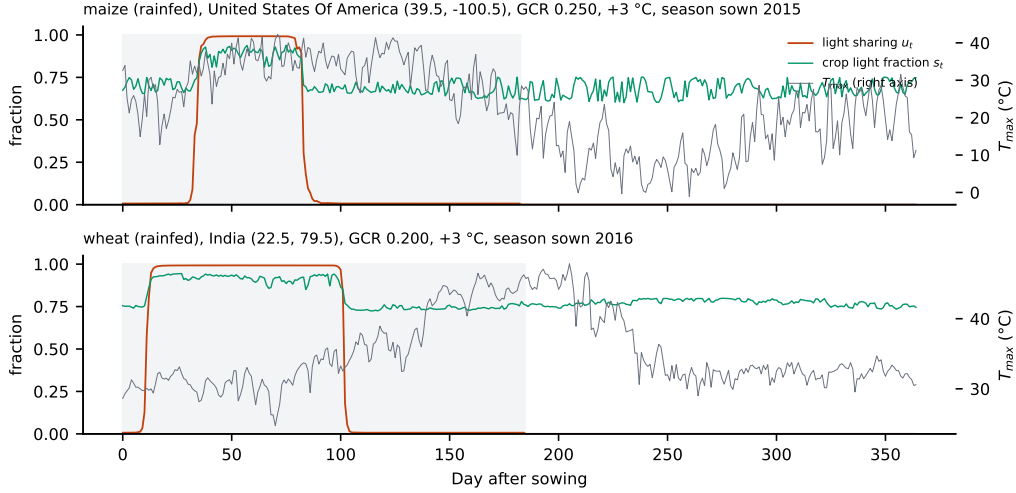


Figure 4: Learned daily control for two test seasons under $+3^{\circ}\text{C}$, at the density chosen for the site, simulated for the dominant sub-field of the site. Shading marks the cropping window. Orange: light-sharing level u_t ; green: fraction of open-field irradiance reaching the crop; grey: daily maximum temperature (right axis).

3.5. Crops and regions

The benefit of light sharing differs between crops (baseline climate, SALS). Soybean and maize tolerate the densest arrays (GCR 0.24 and 0.19; 691 and 577 $\text{MWh ha}^{-1} \text{yr}^{-1}$; LER 1.41 and 1.30), potato follows (0.19; 542; 1.31), and rice and wheat are the most restrictive (0.13 and 0.15; 395 and 428; 1.20 for both). The stress rule has a lower LER for every crop (1.26 for soybean, 1.14–1.21 for the others).

The floor is not met evenly. Production-weighted retention is 0.888 for soybean and 0.898 for maize, below 0.9, because high-yielding seasons lose more than low-yielding ones. Regionally, Latin America and Oceania (4 sites) combine the highest density (GCR 0.41) and electricity (1090 $\text{MWh ha}^{-1} \text{yr}^{-1}$) with a production-weighted retention of only 0.862. Africa and the Middle East (8 sites) reach 0.894, and only 63% of their sites keep a mean retention of at least 0.9. South Asia, the region with the most sites (39), reaches 0.902 (67% of sites) at a density of 0.14. A regulatory floor enforced per site would therefore need a region- and crop-specific design step, not a global one.

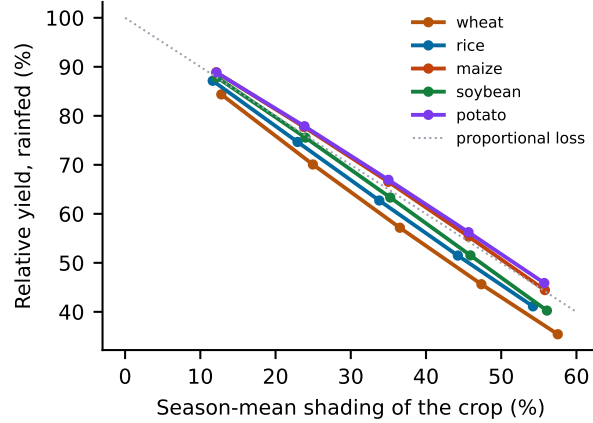


Figure 5: Simulated relative yield of rainfed crops under static arrays (GCR 0.1–0.5) against season-mean shading of the crop, baseline climate, held-out sites. The dotted line is proportional loss.

3.6. Model behaviour and validation

PV output. The simulated specific yield of an isolated tracker row agrees with PVGIS 5.2 (European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2022) at 29 sites with $r = 0.971$, a mean bias of -4.9% and a mean absolute deviation of 5.5% (Section 2.2).

Shade response. Fig. 5 shows the simulated relative yield of rainfed crops under static arrays as a function of the season-mean shading of the crop. Yield declines close to proportionally with shading: 84–89% relative yield at 12% shading, 70–78% at 25%, 57–67% at 37% and 35–46% at 57%. Wheat loses most and potato and maize least. This response is steeper than the *less than proportional* losses that Laub et al. (2022) report for small shade levels of C3 cereals and tubers, and it does not reproduce their finding that maize and grain legumes are more shade sensitive than C3 cereals. In the simulator, shading also relieves heat and drought in rainfed maize and soybean, which offsets the higher harvest-index penalty we assigned to them. The absolute effect of shading on each crop is therefore uncertain (Section 4.4).

3.7. Agrivoltaics under warming

Under warming, the open-field production of the held-out sites (Fig. 6) falls at $+3^\circ\text{C}$ by 23% for maize and 18% for rice, is nearly unchanged for soybean, and rises for wheat ($+3\%$) and potato ($+10\%$). Agrivoltaic production

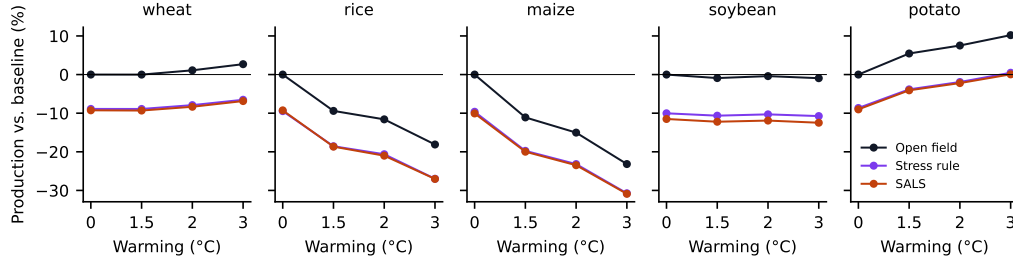


Figure 6: Production relative to the baseline open field (sum over held-out site-seasons) as a function of warming, for the open field, the stress rule and SALS.

with light-sharing control follows the open field at about 90% of its level, so it inherits the same climate impacts (maize -31% , rice -27% relative to the baseline open field at $+3^\circ\text{C}$). Agrivoltaics does not protect staple production against warming in this model. The LER of light-sharing systems increases slightly with warming (SALS 1.270 to 1.297; phenology rule 1.236 to 1.265), because the floor allows slightly denser arrays in warmer conditions (GCR 0.173 to 0.177 and electricity 510 to 540 $\text{MWh ha}^{-1} \text{yr}^{-1}$). The margin of SALS over the rules does not grow with warming (Table A.4).

3.8. Global potential and what it would take

Every site is evaluated when it is held out (219 of the 400 crop-site pairs, in at least one split), and each crop’s mean electricity per hectare is scaled to its physical area in SPAM 2010 (581 Mha for the five crops, which avoids counting multiple-cropped land twice). Equipping 5% of this area (29.1 Mha) with SALS arrays at the floor would produce 14.4 PWh yr^{-1} under the baseline climate and 16.0 PWh yr^{-1} at $+3^\circ\text{C}$, with a production-weighted retention of 0.903 and 0.900. The phenology rule would give 13.0 and 14.5 PWh yr^{-1} , and static arrays 6.4 and 6.9 PWh yr^{-1} . For comparison, world electricity generation was about 30 PWh in 2023 (Ember, 2024).

These numbers require large amounts of hardware. SALS at 5% coverage needs 10.6 TWp of modules (11.3 TWp at $+3^\circ\text{C}$), at a capacity factor of 15.5% (16.2%). World solar PV capacity at the end of 2024 was about 1.9 TW (IRENA, 2025), so the requirement is about 5.7 times the installed PV fleet. The electricity is also variable, peaks at midday and would be curtailed or stored. The figures are technical potentials, not projections. Ordering sites by electricity per hectare gives a supply curve (Fig. 7): the best 2% of the staple cropland would supply 16 PWh yr^{-1} and the best 5% 40 PWh yr^{-1} with

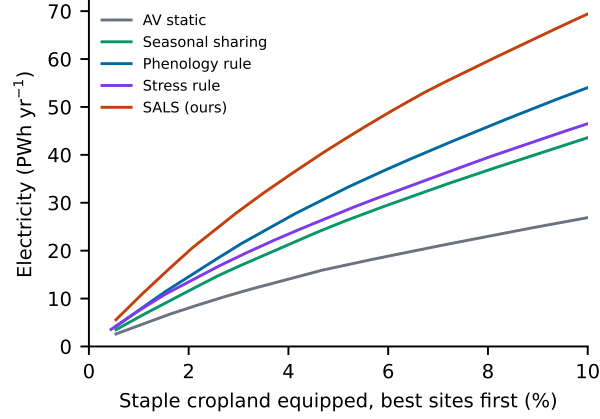


Figure 7: Supply curve under the baseline climate: cumulative electricity when sites are equipped in order of decreasing electricity per hectare, against the share of staple cropland (physical area) equipped. Each controller is evaluated at the density that keeps its mean retention at 0.9.

507 SALS. The best tenth of the sites are mostly rainfed maize and soybean sites
 508 in the Americas and in southern and eastern Africa (7% mean irrigated frac-
 509 tion against 29% overall), which are also among the regions where the floor
 510 is hardest to meet (Section 3.5). Siting by electricity alone would therefore
 511 concentrate agrivoltaics where food-security risk is highest.

512 4. Discussion

513 4.1. What the results establish

514 Three findings stand on consistent evidence. First, sharing light with the
 515 crop is the main lever on the electricity that agrivoltaic arrays can produce
 516 under a yield floor. With static trackers the floor limits arrays to about 6%
 517 ground coverage and an LER of 1.07. Any light-sharing control allows about
 518 three times the density, and the LER rises to 1.18–1.24 for hand-written
 519 rules. Second, a controller learned through the differentiable simulator is
 520 better than the best rule we could write, by 0.03–0.05 in LER and about
 521 10% in electricity at equal retention. The gain is small compared with the
 522 gap between static and dynamic control. It is, however, reproducible over
 523 training seeds (range 0.002 in LER), three spatial splits, three canopy-cooling
 524 assumptions and four climates, and it is found at 84–86% of the held-out
 525 sites. Third, the learned controller is a smooth function of crop phenology.

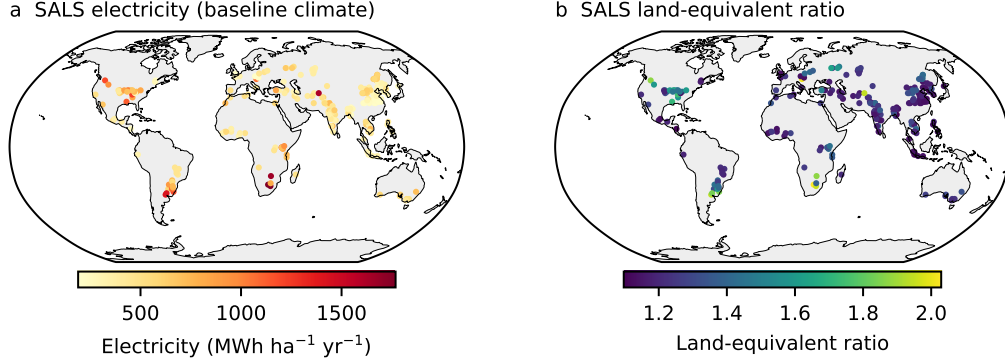


Figure 8: SALS electricity (a) and land-equivalent ratio (b) at the pooled held-out sites (baseline climate, mean of seasons 2015–2019).

It shares light almost fully across the middle of the season, and it produces electricity at the beginning and the end. Our ablations show that it does not use stress information, and that it does not need training in warmed climates, to achieve the gain.

The modest size of the learned gain should be stated as a result. The phenology rule already contains the main idea, and the learned schedule refines its timing. A reader who needs a simple, auditable controller can implement the phenology rule and obtain about 85% of the electricity gain of SALS over static arrays. The learned controller has two further properties that we measured (Section 3.3). It was trained once, at a floor of 0.9, and keeps its advantage over the phenology rule at floors between 0.80 and 0.95 (+0.033 to +0.037 in LER under the baseline climate), so one network serves regulations with different floors. Its result is also identical to three decimals for forecast errors up to three times those of training, because it relies on crop phenology, not on weather forecasts, whereas the stress rule degrades with forecast error. These are practical advantages, not larger gains in electricity. Two other routes that we expected to add value did not: conditioning the network on the floor, and chance-constrained training, gave no improvement.

4.2. What the results do not establish

The early hypothesis that stress-aware control, that is, shading the crop on heat and drought days, would be a main source of benefit under warming was not supported. The stress rule performs worse than the phenology rule in every climate, and a learned controller without stress inputs performs as

well as one with them. A plausible reason is that in our crop model the yield gain from shading on a hot or dry day is smaller than the loss of light on that day, so stress information does not help. Whether this holds for crop models with more detailed canopy-temperature and heat-stress responses is an open question. Agrivoltaics does not protect staple production against warming in our simulations: light-sharing systems produce about 90% of the open-field yield in every climate and follow the same decline in maize and rice (Fig. 6).

4.3. Food security in practice

Holding the historical mean retention at 90% does not hold it in each season or at each site. 70% of SALS seasons meet the floor, the lower tail is slightly heavier than for the rules, and production-weighted retention is below 0.9 for soybean (0.888) and maize (0.898) and in several regions. Chance-constrained design raises season-level compliance to about 92% at a cost of 0.065 in LER, and the ranking of the controllers is preserved. Whichever formulation is chosen, a per-site regulatory floor would need a region- and crop-specific design step. The upscaled potential (Section 3.8) shows the trade-off in magnitude. The 14 PWh yr⁻¹ that 5% of the staple cropland could supply need about 10 TWp of modules, several times the present global fleet, and the best sites are rainfed maize and soybean areas where production-weighted retention is lowest.

4.4. Limitations

- *Simulation only.* All results come from a simulator. PV output was benchmarked against PVGIS (29 sites, mean bias -4.9%), but crop yield under shade was not validated against trial data. The simulated shade response is close to proportional and does not reproduce the ranking of shade tolerance among crop types reported in meta-analyses (Laub et al., 2022). The harvest-index sensitivities h are assumptions.
- *Canopy cooling.* The effect of shade on canopy temperature was represented by one coefficient κ , applied to a heat-stress function that was calibrated on air temperature (Siebert et al., 2014; Webber et al., 2018). The ranking of the controllers is robust to κ between 0 and 2°C, but the absolute electricity changes by about $\pm 8\%$. Nocturnal warming under modules and rain redistribution are not modelled.

- 583 • *Crop model.* SIMPLE has a fixed harvest index and linear radiation-
584 use efficiency. More detailed models with grain-number formation and
585 canopy energy balance may favour different schedules.
- 586 • *Climate scenarios.* Warming was applied as uniform temperature shifts
587 with fixed precipitation, radiation and relative humidity, and with un-
588 changed cultivars and sowing dates. It is not a bias-adjusted climate
589 projection.
- 590 • *Initialisation and state information.* The network is initialised from the
591 phenology rule, because training from random weights collapsed to full
592 sharing. The gain of SALS is therefore the gain of fine-tuning that rule,
593 and we cannot say whether a better optimiser or a richer policy class
594 would find larger gains. The controller uses the simulated state of the
595 crop and soil (thermal time, canopy interception, soil water) without
596 measurement error, and the forecast errors we tested apply to weather
597 only.
- 598 • *Economics and deployment.* There is no cost, market or grid analysis.
599 The value of midday electricity, curtailment, storage, structural cost
600 and farmer acceptance (Trommsdorff et al., 2021) will determine the
601 realisable share. The average row pitch at the chosen densities (about
602 13 m for 2.2-m modules) leaves room for machinery, but the densest
603 designs (GCR up to 0.5) have a pitch of only 4.4 m.

604 5. Conclusions

605 A differentiable simulator of trackers, PV output, crop light, microclimate
606 and crop growth allowed us to compare agrivoltaic controllers fairly on 400
607 crop–site pairs, with the array density of each site chosen from its own history.
608 At a mean yield retention of 90%, light-sharing control allows about three
609 times the module density of static arrays, raising the land-equivalent ratio
610 from 1.07 to 1.18–1.24 with hand-written rules and to 1.27 with a learned
611 controller. The learned controller improves on the best rule by 0.03–0.05 in
612 LER (about 10% more electricity), reproducibly over seeds, spatial splits,
613 canopy-cooling assumptions and climates. The improvement comes from a
614 smooth phenology-dependent schedule, not from reacting to heat or drought.
615 The yield floor is met on average but not in every season or region, and the
616 electricity potential of 5% of staple cropland (about 14 PWh yr⁻¹) requires

about 10 TWp of modules. Future work should validate the crop response to shade under trackers with field data, extend the crop model to grain-number formation and canopy energy balance, add costs and grid constraints, and pursue controllers that guarantee the food-security floor per site and per season.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Quang-Vinh Dang: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of competing interest

The author has no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data and code availability

All data used are public: SPAM 2010 v2r0 harvested areas (Yu et al., 2020), the GGCM Phase 3 crop calendar (Jägermeyr et al., 2021), NASA POWER daily weather (Sparks, 2018) and the SIMPLE crop parameters (Zhao et al., 2019). The code of the simulator, of SALS and of all experiments, together with the site list, is available from the author’s public repository (<https://github.com/vinhqdang/Artificial-Intelligence-in-Agriculture>).

Funding

This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

Appendix A. Statistical comparison

References

Adeh, E.H., Good, S.P., Calaf, M., Higgins, C.W., 2019. Solar pv power potential is greatest over croplands. *Scientific Reports* 9, 11442. doi:10.1038/s41598-019-47803-3.

645 Allen, R.G., Pereira, L.S., Raes, D., Smith, M., 1998. Crop evapotranspiration: Guidelines for computing crop water requirements. FAO Irrigation
646 and Drainage Paper 56. Food and Agriculture Organization of the United
647 Nations. Rome.

649 Amaducci, S., Yin, X., Colauzzi, M., 2018. Agrivoltaic systems to optimise
650 land use for electric energy production. *Applied Energy* 220, 545–561.
651 doi:10.1016/j.apenergy.2018.03.081.

652 Andrade, F.H., Vega, C., Uhart, S., Cirilo, A., Cantarero, M., Valentinuz, O.,
653 1999. Kernel number determination in maize. *Crop Science* 39, 453–459.
654 doi:10.2135/cropsci1999.0011183X0039000200026x.

655 Barron-Gafford, G.A., Pavao-Zuckerman, M.A., Minor, R.L., Sutter, L.F.,
656 Barnett-Moreno, I., Blackett, D.T., Thompson, M., Dimond, K., Gerlak,
657 A.K., Nabhan, G.P., Macknick, J.E., 2019. Agrivoltaics provide mutual
658 benefits across the food–energy–water nexus in drylands. *Nature Sustain-*
659 *ability* 2, 848–855. doi:10.1038/s41893-019-0364-5.

660 Collares-Pereira, M., Rabl, A., 1979. The average distribution of solar
661 radiation-correlations between diffuse and hemispherical and between daily
662 and hourly insolation values. *Solar Energy* 22, 155–164. doi:10.1016/
663 0038-092x(79)90100-2.

664 DIN, 2021. DIN SPEC 91434:2021-05: Agri-photovoltaic systems – require-
665 ments for primary agricultural use. Beuth Verlag, Berlin.

666 Dinesh, H., Pearce, J.M., 2016. The potential of agrivoltaic systems. *Renew-*
667 *able and Sustainable Energy Reviews* 54, 299–308. doi:10.1016/j.rser.
668 2015.10.024.

669 Dupraz, C., Marrou, H., Talbot, G., Dufour, L., Nogier, A., Ferard, Y., 2011.
670 Combining solar photovoltaic panels and food crops for optimising land
671 use: Towards new agrivoltaic schemes. *Renewable Energy* 36, 2725–2732.
672 doi:10.1016/j.renene.2011.03.005.

673 Elamri, Y., Cheviron, B., Lopez, J.M., Dejean, C., Belaud, G., 2018. Water
674 budget and crop modelling for agrivoltaic systems: Application to irrigated
675 lettuces. *Agricultural Water Management* 208, 440–453. doi:10.1016/j.
676 agwat.2018.07.001.

677 Ember, 2024. Global Electricity Review 2024. Technical Report. Ember.
678 London.

679 European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2022. Photovoltaic geo-
680 graphical information system (PVGIS), version 5.2. https://re.jrc.ec.europa.eu/pvg_tools/.
681

682 Fischer, R.A., 1985. Number of kernels in wheat crops and the influence of
683 solar radiation and temperature. *The Journal of Agricultural Science* 105,
684 447–461. doi:10.1017/S0021859600056495.

685 Gautron, R., Maillard, O.A., Preux, P., Corbeels, M., Sabbadin, R., 2022.
686 Reinforcement learning for crop management support: Review, prospects
687 and challenges. *Computers and Electronics in Agriculture* 200, 107182.
688 doi:10.1016/j.compag.2022.107182.

689 Hassanpour Adeg, E., Selker, J.S., Higgins, C.W., 2018. Remarkable agri-
690 voltaic influence on soil moisture, micrometeorology and water-use effi-
691 ciency. *PLOS ONE* 13, e0203256. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0203256.

692 IRENA, 2025. Renewable Capacity Statistics 2025. Technical Report. Inter-
693 national Renewable Energy Agency. Abu Dhabi.

694 Jägermeyr, J., Müller, C., Ruane, A.C., Elliott, J., Balkovic, J., Castillo, O.,
695 Faye, B., Foster, I., Folberth, C., Franke, J.A., Fuchs, K., Guarin, J.R.,
696 Heinke, J., Hoogenboom, G., Iizumi, T., Jain, A.K., Kelly, D., Khabarov,
697 N., Lange, S., Lin, T.S., Liu, W., Mialyk, O., Minoli, S., Moyer, E.J.,
698 Okada, M., Phillips, M., Porter, C., Rabin, S.S., Scheer, C., Schneider,
699 J.M., Schyns, J.F., Skalsky, R., Smerald, A., Stella, T., Stephens, H.,
700 Webber, H., Zabel, F., Rosenzweig, C., 2021. Climate impacts on global
701 agriculture emerge earlier in new generation of climate and crop models.
702 *Nature Food* 2, 873–885. doi:10.1038/s43016-021-00400-y.

703 Karniadakis, G.E., Kevrekidis, I.G., Lu, L., Perdikaris, P., Wang, S., Yang,
704 L., 2021. Physics-informed machine learning. *Nature Reviews Physics* 3,
705 422–440. doi:10.1038/s42254-021-00314-5.

706 Kingma, D.P., Ba, J., 2015. Adam: A method for stochastic optimization,
707 in: *International Conference on Learning Representations*.

- Laub, M., Pataczek, L., Feuerbacher, A., Zikeli, S., Högy, P., 2022. Contrasting yield responses at varying levels of shade suggest different suitability of crops for dual land-use systems: a meta-analysis. *Agronomy for Sustainable Development* 42, 51. doi:10.1007/s13593-022-00783-7.
- Liu, B.Y., Jordan, R.C., 1960. The interrelationship and characteristic distribution of direct, diffuse and total solar radiation. *Solar Energy* 4, 1–19. doi:10.1016/0038-092x(60)90062-1.
- Lorenzo, E., Narvarte, L., Muñoz, J., 2011. Tracking and back-tracking. *Progress in Photovoltaics: Research and Applications* 19, 747–753. doi:10.1002/pip.1085.
- Marrou, H., Dufour, L., Wery, J., 2013a. How does a shelter of solar panels influence water flows in a soil–crop system? *European Journal of Agronomy* 50, 38–51. doi:10.1016/j.eja.2013.05.004.
- Marrou, H., Guilioni, L., Dufour, L., Dupraz, C., Wery, J., 2013b. Microclimate under agrivoltaic systems: Is crop growth rate affected in the partial shade of solar panels? *Agricultural and Forest Meteorology* 177, 117–132. doi:10.1016/j.agrformet.2013.04.012.
- Paszke, A., Gross, S., Massa, F., Lerer, A., Bradbury, J., Chanan, G., Killeen, T., Lin, Z., Gimelshein, N., Antiga, L., et al., 2019. PyTorch: An imperative style, high-performance deep learning library, in: *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*, pp. 8024–8035.
- Ramos-Fuentes, I.A., Elamri, Y., Cheviron, B., Dejean, C., Belaud, G., Fumey, D., 2023. Effects of shade and deficit irrigation on maize growth and development in fixed and dynamic agrivoltaic systems. *Agricultural Water Management* 280, 108187. doi:10.1016/j.agwat.2023.108187.
- Siebert, S., Ewert, F., Eyshi Rezaei, E., Kage, H., Graß, R., 2014. Impact of heat stress on crop yield—on the importance of considering canopy temperature. *Environmental Research Letters* 9, 044012. doi:10.1088/1748-9326/9/4/044012.
- Sparks, A., 2018. nasapower: A nasa power global meteorology, surface solar energy and climatology data client for r. *Journal of Open Source Software* 3, 1035. doi:10.21105/joss.01035.

- 740 Trommsdorff, M., Kang, J., Reise, C., Schindele, S., Bopp, G., Ehmann, A.,
741 Weselek, A., Högy, P., Obergfell, T., 2021. Combining food and energy
742 production: Design of an agrivoltaic system applied in arable and vegetable
743 farming in germany. *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews* 140,
744 110694. doi:10.1016/j.rser.2020.110694.
- 745 Valle, B., Simonneau, T., Sourd, F., Pechier, P., Hamard, P., Frisson, T.,
746 Ryckewaert, M., Christophe, A., 2017. Increasing the total productivity of
747 a land by combining mobile photovoltaic panels and food crops. *Applied*
748 *Energy* 206, 1495–1507. doi:10.1016/j.apenergy.2017.09.113.
- 749 Waha, K., Dietrich, J.P., Portmann, F.T., Siebert, S., Thornton, P.K., Bon-
750 deau, A., Herrero, M., 2020. Multiple cropping systems of the world
751 and the potential for increasing cropping intensity. *Global Environmental*
752 *Change* 64, 102131. doi:10.1016/j.gloenvcha.2020.102131.
- 753 Webber, H., White, J.W., Kimball, B.A., Ewert, F., Asseng, S., Eyshi Rezaei,
754 E., Pinter, P.J., Hatfield, J.L., Reynolds, M.P., Ababaei, B., Bindi, M.,
755 Doltra, J., Ferrise, R., Kage, H., Kassie, B.T., Kersebaum, K.C., Luig,
756 A., Olesen, J.E., Semenov, M.A., Stratonovitch, P., Ratjen, A.M., LaM-
757 orte, R.L., Leavitt, S.W., Hunsaker, D.J., Wall, G.W., Martre, P., 2018.
758 Physical robustness of canopy temperature models for crop heat stress
759 simulation across environments and production conditions. *Field Crops*
760 *Research* 216, 75–88. doi:10.1016/j.fcr.2017.11.005.
- 761 Weselek, A., Bauerle, A., Hartung, J., Zikeli, S., Lewandowski, I., Högy, P.,
762 2021. Agrivoltaic system impacts on microclimate and yield of different
763 crops within an organic crop rotation in a temperate climate. *Agronomy*
764 *for Sustainable Development* 41, 59. doi:10.1007/s13593-021-00714-y.
- 765 Weselek, A., Ehmann, A., Zikeli, S., Lewandowski, I., Schindele, S., Högy,
766 P., 2019. Agrophotovoltaic systems: applications, challenges, and op-
767 portunities. a review. *Agronomy for Sustainable Development* 39, 35.
768 doi:10.1007/s13593-019-0581-3.
- 769 Woli, P., Jones, J.W., Ingram, K.T., Fraisse, C.W., 2012. Agricultural
770 reference index for drought (arid). *Agronomy Journal* 104, 287–300.
771 doi:10.2134/agronj2011.0286.

- 772 Yu, Q., You, L., Wood-Sichra, U., Ru, Y., Joglekar, A.K.B., Fritz, S., Xiong,
773 W., Lu, M., Wu, W., Yang, P., 2020. A cultivated planet in 2010 – part 2:
774 The global gridded agricultural-production maps. *Earth System Science*
775 *Data* 12, 3545–3572. doi:10.5194/essd-12-3545-2020.
- 776 Zhang, L., Geng, X., Ding, H., Cao, K., Wang, L., Chen, H., Deng, L., Wu,
777 C., Xiao, M., Bao, E., 2026. Multi-objective optimization of photovoltaic
778 array layouts on farmland via a hybrid algorithm framework for enhanced
779 agricultural production and energy generation. *Artificial Intelligence in*
780 *Agriculture* doi:10.1016/j.aiia.2026.09.002.
- 781 Zhao, C., Liu, B., Piao, S., Wang, X., Lobell, D.B., Huang, Y., Huang, M.,
782 Yao, Y., Bassu, S., Ciais, P., Durand, J.L., Elliott, J., Ewert, F., Janssens,
783 I.A., Li, T., Lin, E., Liu, Q., Martre, P., Müller, C., Peng, S., Peñuelas,
784 J., Ruane, A.C., Wallach, D., Wang, T., Wu, D., Liu, Z., Zhu, Y., Zhu,
785 Z., Asseng, S., 2017. Temperature increase reduces global yields of major
786 crops in four independent estimates. *Proceedings of the National Academy*
787 *of Sciences* 114, 9326–9331. doi:10.1073/pnas.1701762114.
- 788 Zhao, C., Liu, B., Xiao, L., Hoogenboom, G., Boote, K.J., Kassie, B.T.,
789 Pavan, W., Shelia, V., Kim, K.S., Hernandez-Ochoa, I.M., Wallach, D.,
790 Porter, C.H., Stockle, C.O., Zhu, Y., Asseng, S., 2019. A simple crop
791 model. *European Journal of Agronomy* 104, 97–106. doi:10.1016/j.eja.
792 2019.01.009.

Table 2: Held-out performance (92 test sites, seasons 2015–2019, canopy cooling $\kappa = 1^\circ\text{C}$). The density (GCR) of each site is the largest value on the grid 0.05, 0.075, ..., 0.5 at which the method’s mean retention in the site’s 2001–2014 seasons is ≥ 0.9 . E : electricity ($\text{MWh ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$); e : electricity relative to a conventional PV plant; r : mean yield retention; r_{prod} : production-weighted retention; C_s and C_{site} : share of seasons with $r \geq 0.9$ and share of sites whose test-season mean $r \geq 0.9$ (%); $\text{LER} = r + e$.

Method	GCR	E	e	r	r_{prod}	C_s	C_{site}	LER
<i>Baseline</i>								
AV static	0.06	217	0.16	0.917	0.914	93	96	1.07
Seasonal sharing	0.17	397	0.28	0.904	0.902	69	72	1.19
Phenology rule	0.17	465	0.33	0.904	0.902	69	75	1.24
Stress rule	0.13	387	0.28	0.907	0.907	76	82	1.18
SALS (ours)	0.17	510	0.36	0.905	0.902	70	74	1.27
<i>+1.5 °C</i>								
AV static	0.06	221	0.16	0.916	0.914	93	92	1.08
Seasonal sharing	0.16	393	0.28	0.905	0.903	72	74	1.19
Phenology rule	0.17	478	0.34	0.905	0.902	68	75	1.25
Stress rule	0.12	377	0.27	0.908	0.908	73	77	1.18
SALS (ours)	0.17	518	0.37	0.906	0.903	68	75	1.28
<i>+2 °C</i>								
AV static	0.06	223	0.16	0.916	0.914	92	93	1.08
Seasonal sharing	0.17	394	0.28	0.905	0.904	72	76	1.19
Phenology rule	0.17	483	0.35	0.905	0.903	69	74	1.25
Stress rule	0.12	370	0.26	0.909	0.909	75	78	1.17
SALS (ours)	0.17	521	0.38	0.907	0.904	69	75	1.28
<i>+3 °C</i>								
AV static	0.06	231	0.17	0.915	0.914	88	89	1.08
Seasonal sharing	0.17	397	0.29	0.906	0.904	69	75	1.19
Phenology rule	0.18	499	0.36	0.905	0.902	67	72	1.26
Stress rule	0.11	366	0.26	0.908	0.908	74	77	1.17
SALS (ours)	0.18	540	0.39	0.907	0.904	68	75	1.30

Table 3: LER of the controllers at different yield-retention floors ρ (main split; the historical design step is repeated for each floor).

Method	Baseline climate				+3 °C			
	0.80	0.85	0.90	0.95	0.80	0.85	0.90	0.95
AV static	1.159	1.115	1.072	1.011	1.174	1.128	1.083	1.013
Stress rule	1.380	1.282	1.182	1.077	1.364	1.269	1.172	1.071
Phenology rule	1.467	1.356	1.236	1.108	1.513	1.395	1.265	1.122
SALS (trained at $\rho = 0.9$)	1.505	1.392	1.270	1.141	1.553	1.432	1.297	1.154
SALS conditioned on ρ	1.504	1.391	1.269	1.141	1.553	1.431	1.296	1.154

Table A.4: Paired comparison of SALS with each baseline on the 92 held-out sites of the main split (unit of analysis: site mean over test seasons). ΔLER : mean difference (SALS minus baseline) with cluster-bootstrap 95% CI; p : two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank test; % better: share of sites where SALS has the higher LER; Δr : difference in mean yield retention with its Wilcoxon p -value.

Climate	Baseline	ΔLER [95% CI]	p	% better	Δr	p	Sites
Baseline	AV static	+0.205 [+0.176, +0.236]	$< 10^{-4}$	100	-0.011	$< 10^{-4}$	92
Baseline	Seasonal sharing	+0.088 [+0.068, +0.109]	$< 10^{-4}$	97	+0.001	0.922	92
Baseline	Phenology rule	+0.038 [+0.025, +0.053]	$< 10^{-4}$	84	+0.001	0.723	92
Baseline	Stress rule	+0.096 [+0.071, +0.124]	$< 10^{-4}$	93	-0.002	0.055	92
+1.5 °C	AV static	+0.208 [+0.180, +0.237]	$< 10^{-4}$	100	-0.010	$< 10^{-4}$	92
+1.5 °C	Seasonal sharing	+0.095 [+0.077, +0.114]	$< 10^{-4}$	98	+0.001	0.812	92
+1.5 °C	Phenology rule	+0.033 [+0.022, +0.045]	$< 10^{-4}$	86	+0.002	0.855	92
+1.5 °C	Stress rule	+0.108 [+0.083, +0.134]	$< 10^{-4}$	98	-0.001	0.041	92
+2 °C	AV static	+0.209 [+0.181, +0.238]	$< 10^{-4}$	100	-0.010	$< 10^{-4}$	92
+2 °C	Seasonal sharing	+0.097 [+0.079, +0.115]	$< 10^{-4}$	97	+0.001	0.876	92
+2 °C	Phenology rule	+0.032 [+0.022, +0.044]	$< 10^{-4}$	85	+0.002	0.496	92
+2 °C	Stress rule	+0.115 [+0.089, +0.142]	$< 10^{-4}$	98	-0.003	0.016	92
+3 °C	AV static	+0.219 [+0.190, +0.250]	$< 10^{-4}$	100	-0.009	$< 10^{-4}$	92
+3 °C	Seasonal sharing	+0.108 [+0.089, +0.129]	$< 10^{-4}$	96	+0.001	0.935	92
+3 °C	Phenology rule	+0.034 [+0.022, +0.046]	$< 10^{-4}$	86	+0.002	0.330	92
+3 °C	Stress rule	+0.131 [+0.102, +0.162]	$< 10^{-4}$	98	-0.002	0.142	92